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Unraveling the Mystery of the Handscroll 'Qingming shange tu'

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UNRAVELING THE MYSTERY  
OF THE HANDSCROLL  
'QINGMING SHANGHE TU'

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*The Issues*

The celebrated handscroll *Qingming Shanghe tu* 清明上河圖 has traditionally been viewed either as a realistic record of the Qingming festival in Kaifeng 開封, the Eastern Capital of the Northern Song (960–1127) during the glorious Xuanhe 宣和 era (1119–1125), or as a eulogy of the Northern Song in the beginning of the twelfth century.<sup>1</sup> Many scholars have accepted these interpretations but remained perplexed that neither festival nor specific

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1. The handscroll was acquired for the imperial collection during the Qing Dynasty (1644–1911) and, after the death of Emperor Qianlong (1736–1796), was stored in Yanchun Hall 延春 with other treasures he had enjoyed. See Zhan Zao 張造 et al., comps., *Shiqubaoji sanbian* 石渠寶笈三編 (Rpt., Taipei: National Palace Museum, 1969), 3.1458–64. After the Republic of China was established, treasures from Yanchun Hall began disappearing, and the Republican Government decided to send an inspection team to the palace in 1923. The night before the inspection team arrived a fire burned Yanchun Hall. See also Aixin jueluo Puyi 愛新覺羅溥儀, *Wode qianbansheng* 我的前半生 [The first part of my life] (Hong Kong: Wentong Press, 1964), 2: 311. In an interview I conducted with Yang Renkai 楊仁愷, a former curator of the Liaoning Provincial Museum, he claimed that he rediscovered this scroll in a storage room in Manchuria in 1948. It had survived the 1923 fire and had been taken together with other imperial artworks to the Japanese-occupied Manchuria State in the mid-1920s. There, it was among the trophies received by the Russian Red Army after Japan's surrender at the end of World War II. The handscroll was first shown at the Palace Museum in the early 1950s and was placed in the Museum's permanent collection by Minister of Culture Zheng Zhenduo 鄭振鐸.

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celebratory scenes have been identified in the work.<sup>2</sup> Although it is a well-known and frequently reproduced painting, practically everything about the scroll has been disputed: its author, date, title, subject, season, and the city depicted. In the past decades, research and published studies on this painting have devoted fair amount of time to defining the use of the term *qingming* 清明 in the title of the painting. The term “Qingming” in the painting’s Chinese title is commonly understood as referring to an early spring festival; the phrase also means “peace and brightness.” Thus the title of the painting has been variously translated as *Going Upriver for the Qingming Festival*, *Qingming Festival on the River*, and *Peace Reigns on the River*, the latter praising the orderliness and harmony in a city known for its canals and booming river trade. Despite the research produced on the scroll to date, too few questions based on careful readings of the work and its historical context have been asked.<sup>3</sup> The traditionally accepted subject matters of the painting have also perplexed many scholars. In an essay entitled “The Mystery of the Qingming Scroll and Its Subject: The Case against Kaifeng,” Valerie Hansen points out that none of the typical Qingming festival activities is depicted. She proposes that the

2. The earliest studies of the painting are Zheng Zhenduo, “Qingming shanghe tu de yanjiu” 〈清明上河圖〉的研究, in Zhang Qiang 張薈, ed., *Zheng Zhenduo meishu wenji* 鄭振鐸美術文集 [Essays on Art by Zheng Zhenduo] (Beijing: Renminmeishu press, 1985), 221–247, and Xu Bangda 徐邦達, “Qingming shanghe tu de chubu yanjiu” 清明上河圖的初步研究, *Gugong bowuyuan yuankan* 故宮博物院院刊 1 (1958): 35–49. Both scholars identify the scroll as a festival celebration along the Bian River and date it to the early twelfth century. Richard Barnhart, one of the few art historians to propose a different date, suggests the mid-eleventh century. See Barnhart, “The Five Dynasties (907–960) and the Song Period (960–1279)” in Yang Xin 楊新 et al., *Three Thousand Years of Chinese Painting* (New Haven and Beijing: Yale University Press and Waiwen Press, 1997), 105. Other studies include Roderick Whitfield, “Chang Tse-tuan’s *Ch’ing-ming shang-he t’u*” (Ph.D. diss., Princeton University, 1965), and “Chang Tse-tuan’s *Ching-ming shang-he t’u*” in *Proceedings of the International Symposium on Chinese Painting* (Taipei, 1972), 349–88; Zhang Anzhi 張安治, *Qingming shanghe tu* 清明上河圖 [On the painting “Spring Festival on the River”] (Beijing: Renminmeishu Press, 1979); Valerie Hansen, “The Mystery of the Qingming Scroll and Its Subject: The Case against Kaifeng,” *Journal of Sung-Yuan Studies* 26 (1996): 169–182; Linda Cooke Johnson, “The Place of *Qingming shanghe tu* in the Historical Geography of Song dynasty Dongjing,” *Journal of Sung-Yuan Studies* 26 (1996): 183–200; and Yang Xin, “Qingming shanghe tu dili weizhi xiaokao” 清明上河圖地理位置小考, *Meishu yanjiu* 美術研究 2 (1979): 75–76.

3. The research for this article is based on electronic images of the scroll that were digitized from high quality transparencies taken directly from the painting. I was able to enlarge the high-resolution images, section by section, to 50 times of their original size without breaking the image into pixels. Only by so doing did I have the opportunity fully to understand the work and to propose, in this paper, a new interpretation of the subject matter of this handscroll.

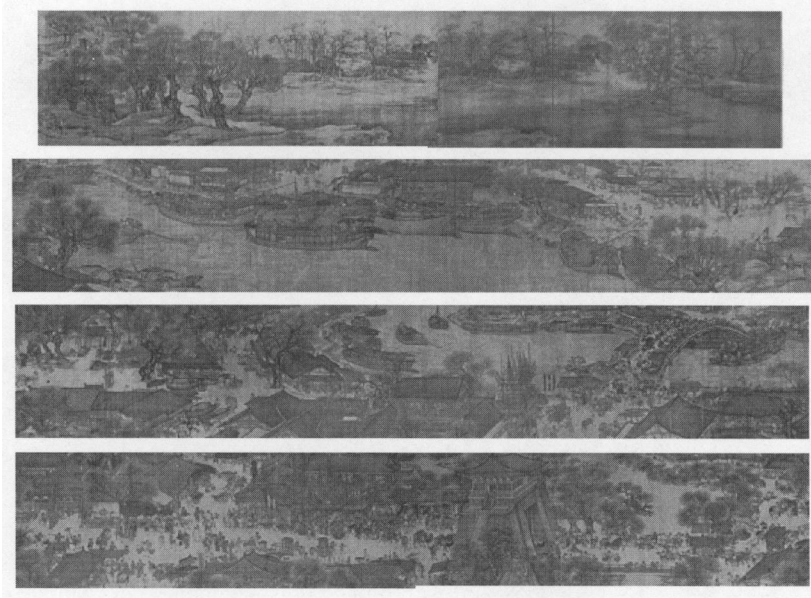


Fig. 1. Zhang Zeduan 張擇端, attri. *Qingming Shanghe tu* 清明上河圖, (ink and colors on silk, 24.8 x 528.7 cm) courtesy of the Palace Museum, Beijing.

scroll is a four-season eulogy of a regime.<sup>4</sup> Since the title of the painting has been a subject of controversy for decades, I will, in order to establish a new reading, refer to it as *Up to the Capital*.

While many other scholars continue to view it as a painting referring to the Qingming Festival, it seems to some others and me that some of these discussions have stemmed from a misunderstanding of the phrase *qingming* itself. Because the silk on which it is painted has darkened with age, it is nearly impossible to read its nuances with bare eyes. In the last few years, I was able to digitalize large size transparencies of the painting and read it through these vastly enlarged, high resolution digital images. In this way I was able to see clues that were not apparent otherwise. Based on visual evidence in the painting, I will argue below that the scroll depicts the bustling traffic along the Bian River (fig. 1) on the first day of the Qingming term (early April),<sup>5</sup> and the

4. See Hansen, "Mystery" and Yang Xin, "Qingming."

5. Unlike the government ceremonial calendar, which was lunar-based, the Chinese agricultural calendar was (and is) solar-based, and was divided into 24 terms. Each term had 15

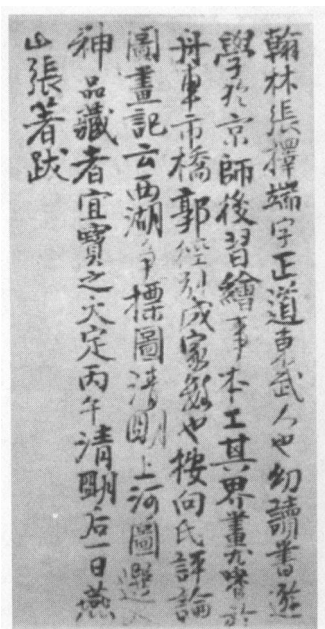


Fig. 2. Zhang Zhu's colophon, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

resultant prosperity river commerce brought to the capital. Using written works from and about the Northern Song and visual evidence from the painting, I will argue that the scroll depicts scenes that directly violate regulations for the Qingming festival as it was celebrated during the Song Dynasty. The handscroll, instead, represents a busy transportation and commercial season commencing on the first day of Qingming, as I shall discuss in detail later. Based on my reading of the digitalized images, the scenes depicted in the painting strongly suggest that this “mysterious” city was Kaifeng.

Immediately following the painting *Up to the Capital* is a colophon written by Zhang Zhu (active late twelfth century) (see fig. 2). Based on his reading in an earlier catalog, Zhang Zhu identifies Zhang Zeduan as the artist and recognizes the title of this work as *Qingming shanghe tu*.<sup>6</sup> The colophon reads:

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or 16 days, yielding a year of 365 days. The form of the calendar current in Song times and after was largely based on Liu An 劉安 (d. 122 B.C.E.), *Huainanzi* (Zhongguo zixue mingzhu jichen edition, Taipei, 1977) 85.87–128.

6. When this colophon was composed, the Cold-food Festival and the Qingming Festival had already merged as one. See discussion below. Following this colophon are others transcribed in Zhang Zhao, *Shiqu baoji sanbian*, 3.1458–64. They are reproduced in *Zhongguo lidai huihua*:

翰林張擇端，字正道，東武人也。幼讀書，遊學於京師，後習繪事，本工其界畫，尤嗜於舟車，市橋，郭徑。別成家數也。按向氏評論圖畫記云：西湖爭標圖，清明上河圖選入神品，藏者宜寶之。

大定丙午清明後一日。燕山張著跋。

Hanlin [Academician] Zhang Zeduan, courtesy name Zhengdao, was a native of Dongwu. He went to the capital to study when he was young. Later he learned painting. He mastered *jiehua* [architectural painting often done with a ruler] and took particular pleasure in depicting boats, carts, markets, bridges, city walls, and streets. He even established his own style. According to Mr. Xiang's *Critiques on paintings*, [the works] *Xihu zhengbiao tu* [Dragon Boat Regatta on the West Lake] and *Qingming shanghe tu* belong to the divine class; collectors should treasure them.

Postscripted by Zhang Zhu of Yanshan on the day after Qingming (fifth solar term) in the year *bingwu* of the Dading period [1186].

From this inscription, we learn that the title of the scroll may or may not relate to the Qingming Festival. Later colophon writers, some from long after the end of the Northern Song, commented that the scenes depicted were of city life in the twelfth century. Although most scholars believe the scroll to be from around this period, others, including myself, consider it a work of the eleventh century.<sup>7</sup> As I shall show below, the dating of this painting is closely related to its subject matter, and would have been difficult for outsiders to understand once the context was lost. In this essay, I will try to restore the context for the painting in order to establish a new dating for the painting as well as a new reading of it.

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*Gugong bowuyuan canghua ji* 中國歷代繪畫：故宮博物院藏畫集 [Chinese paintings from all periods: The painting collection from the Palace Museum], vol. 2 (Beijing: Renminmeishu Press, 1981). Roderick Whitfield has translated some of them in his doctoral dissertation (Whitfield, "Chang Tse-tuan's *Ch'ing-ming shang-he t'u*"). The painting was reproduced in scroll format with colophons in both 1980 and 1988 in Beijing.

7. Richard Barnhart, who dates the painting to around the beginning of the eleventh century, believes that it is stylistically related to the works of the early Northern Song masters such as Gao Keming (高克明 active ca. 1008–1053) and Yan Wengui (燕文貴 active ca. 1000). See Barnhart, "The Five Dynasties (907–960) and the Song Period (960–1279)," 105. In earlier versions of this paper, I accepted the later date proposed by most scholars, but based on the scrutiny of the enlarged digital images I am now convinced the scroll can be dated no later than the end of the eleventh century.

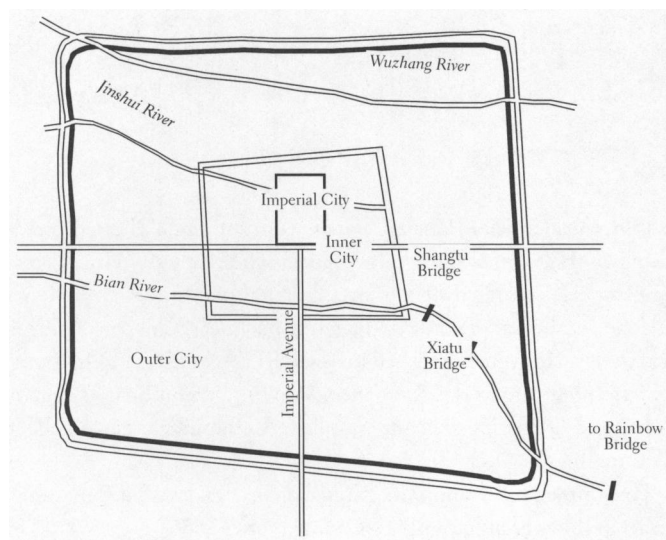


Fig. 3. Reconstructed Map of Dongjing, the Eastern Capital of the Northern Song.

The scroll consists of three major sections, each depicting a distinct locale: an area between the outer and inner city walls, the river, and a part of the inner city (see fig. 3). The painting is highly realistic: “[there] seems to be no other Song painting of such intense realism, so given to full and accurate description and so sovereignly indifferent to formalistic concerns.”<sup>8</sup> The dramatic visual center of the painting, as well as its physical center, is a beautiful rainbow-shaped bridge. The river’s current moves from left to right while the viewer’s eyes travel from right to left—from the outer city to the inner city. The center of the scroll is populated with boats loading and unloading goods and passengers.

Reading the scroll from right to left, a viewers’ eye is directed to a road, then a river is introduced. A group of donkeys carrying baskets filled with charcoal make their way along the road toward the viewer. Clusters of houses and a vegetable farm (fig. 4), and a section of the Bian River become visible.<sup>9</sup> Here

8. Max Loehr, *The Great Painters of China* (New York: Harper and Row, 1980), 165.

9. Urbanization is a very recent phenomenon in China. Dirt roads and small farms were found between Beijing’s inner and outer city walls as recently as the last century. See G. William Skinner, ed., *The City in Late Imperial China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1977), 69.



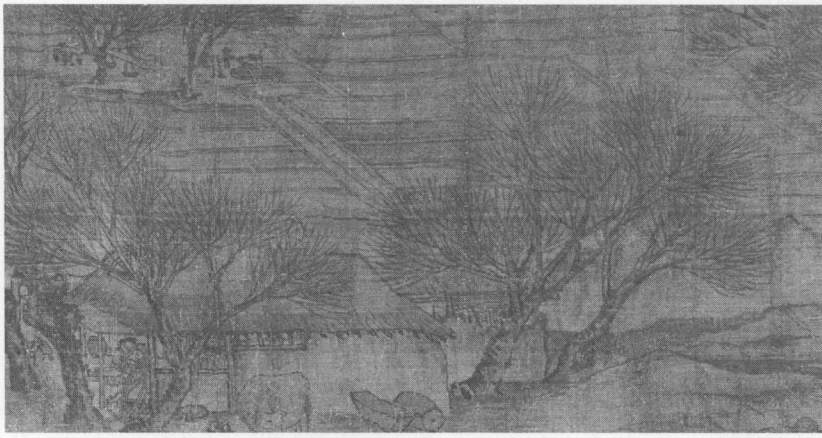


Fig. 4 Vegetable farms, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

begins the second section, where various types of boats are depicted.<sup>10</sup> They carry passengers, grain, and other goods up the river, and in many places cargo is being unloaded and piled on the riverbank. An intense drama unfolds beneath the rainbow bridge, where two boats are on the verge of colliding. Beyond the bridge, the third section commences at a spectacular city gate. As the eye moves farther to the left, the number of shops increases, and the crowds grow thicker and merrier—the action and movement seems to mirror the flow of the river. Then, suddenly, the bustling activity comes to an end at a gate near a medical clinic that claims to cure hangovers, and the scroll ends. The whole scroll seems to highlight one theme: the transportation that brought prosperity to the capital in the time of spring.

Spring was a particularly important time for grain transportation; it also was a popular subject for painting during the Northern Song. The favorite court artist of Emperor Shenzong, Guo Xi 郭熙, painted *Early Spring* (*Zaochun tu*) 早春圖 in 1072 to announce the emperor's reign and symbolize him as a young and ambitious ruler.<sup>11</sup> A few years later, after the Bian had been rerouted so boats could travel to the capital all year round, Emperor Shenzong had Guo

10. I suggest below that the boats and ships shown in the painting were used to illustrate the technological developments in shipbuilding during this period. See Needham et al., eds., *Science and Civilization in China*, 6: 2376.

11. Alfreda Murck, *Poetry and Painting in Song China: The Subtle Art of Dissent* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2000), 37.



Xi paint the landscape mural *Morning Scenes on a Spring River* (*Chunjiang xiaojing*) 春江曉景. This monumental work glorifies early spring along the river at the Institute of Academicians (*xueshi yuan* 學士院).<sup>12</sup>

### *The Capital*

It has been generally accepted that *Up to the Capital* contains no architectural or geographical landmarks that readily identify it as a specific city of the Song Dynasty. The rainbow-shaped bridge was not unique to any one city; in fact more than one rainbow bridge had been built along the Bian River. This single piece of evidence is hardly enough to confirm that the city depicted is Kaifeng. However, digitally enhanced images have made it possible to discover evidence that clearly identifies the city as the Eastern Capital of the Northern Song Dynasty.

On the left side of the splendid gate is a restaurant in front of which some people enter, others exit, and still others stop by a flower stand to make a purchase. Behind them is a neat pile of wine containers (fig. 5). A sign that reads “*zhengdian* 正店,” meaning “main shop,” or “primary wine house” (fig. 6) indicates that this is an important wine shop. According to Meng Yuanlao 孟元老, “there were seventy-two primary wine houses in the capital, and so many others they cannot be enumerated. The rest of them were called ‘*jiaodian* 腳店,’ ‘foot-rest inn,’ ‘retail store,’ or ‘secondary houses.’”<sup>13</sup> Only primary wine houses had facilities and the government’s permission to produce wine; secondary houses merely sold it. Here and there we see banners reading “*xiaojiu* 小酒” “minor wine” in front of small shops.

Many signs placed in front of a wine shop located to the left of the rainbow bridge confirm that this is a shop in the Eastern Capital. Fully exposed to the viewer, the wine shop also states the painting’s secondary subject matter: efficiency of grain transport brought opulence to the city and consequently supported the wine culture, as is evident from the carefully displayed wine-

12. Ye Mengde 葉夢德 (1077–1148), *Shilin yanyu* 石林燕語 [Notes from retirement in a stone forest], (rpt., Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1984 [1997]) 4.56. Institute of Academicians was established in 738 for court officials holding concurrent appointments. See C. Hucker, *A Dictionary of Official Titles in Imperial China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1985), 253.

13. Meng Yuanlao 孟元老, *Dongjing menghua lu* 東京夢華錄 [Glorious Dreams of the Eastern Capital] (originally published in 1147), in Tao Zongyi 陶宗儀, ed., *Shuo Fu*. (1647 edition) 68: 1.3a.



Fig. 5. A neat pile of wine containers behind the main wine shop, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.



Fig. 6. Sign of *Zhengdian* (main wine shop), a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

related visual elements. The prominent yet delicately painted wine shop, along with numerous other wine shops in the work, underscores this theme. For so many wine shops to thrive, there must be a profusion of grain transported to the city, since only about twenty pounds of wine can be produced from one hundred pounds of grain. Many signs adorn the doors, demonstrating

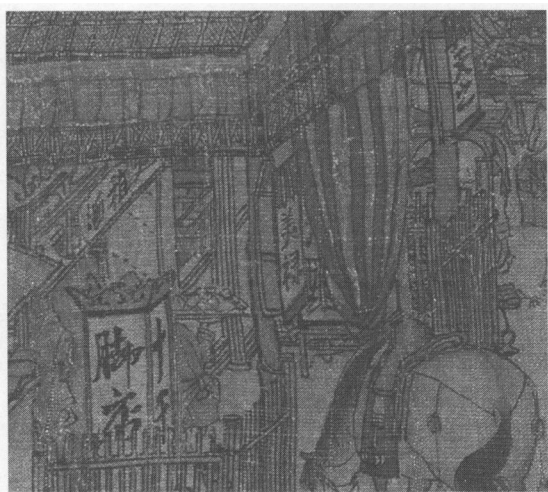


Fig. 7. Sign of *Jiadian* (branch wine shop), a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.



Fig. 8. Sign of *Meilu* wine, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

Kaifeng's spectacular growth and the opulence that stimulated the rich wine culture.

In front of a secondary wine shop is a sign with the two characters “*jiadian*” 腳店 (fig. 7) indicating that wine served here would have been supplied by one of the nearby main shops. Wine production was strictly regulated during the Northern Song—more so than in previous dynasties. By controlling the sale of distiller's yeast produced by the government, officials were able to control the manufacture and, in turn, the sale of wine. Government-made yeast was used by all of the main wine businesses in the capital, so the amount of wine made and sold in any given area could be carefully monitored.<sup>14</sup> The transportation of wine for sale or in large quantities was strictly forbidden, and those found guilty of the crime could be severely punished. Farmers were allowed to purchase and transport wine in quantity only for weddings or funerals.<sup>15</sup>

Nearby the “foot-rest inn” sign, a panel reads “*meilu* 美祿” (fig. 8). The *Jiuming ji* 酒名記 [Record of Wines], compiled by Zhang Nengcheng 張能

14. *Song shi* 宋史 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1972), 185.4513–4516.

15. *Song shi*, 185.4516.



Fig. 9. Sign of a medical doctor advertising himself as specialist of curing hangovers.

臣 during the Northern Song, lists “Meilu” as a wine produced by Liangzhai yuanzi zhengdian 梁宅園子正店, one of the privately owned establishments in Kaifeng that used government-made yeast.<sup>16</sup> Of the seventy-two main shops in the capital, twenty-six are listed by Zhang Nengcheng, and Liangzhai yuanzi is among them. The shop and its wine must have been fairly well known and may even have been the pride and joy of the region. In the Meilu sign we finally have a “landmark” that definitively identifies Kaifeng 開封 as the city depicted in *Up to the Capital*.

Given the presence of so many wine shops, a sign in front of the medical clinic proclaiming its doctor to be an expert at curing hangovers seems particularly appropriate (fig. 9). *Up to the Capital* is a portrait of a city that has the tendency, and the means, to overindulge. What makes this possible is not so much the productivity of its inhabitants as the efficiency of its river transportation—even in early spring, when grain shortages were most common.

16. Zhu Bian 朱卞, *Quwei jiuwen* 酒消舊聞 (Zhaokuang ge edition) 7.11a. See also Zhang Nengcheng 張能臣, “Jiuming ji” 酒名記, in Tao Zongyi, ed., *Shuo Fu* (1647 edition) 94: 12.2a.

When other parts of China could have been experiencing food shortages, the people of Kaifeng were enjoying food and wine in abundance.

Many later Qingming scrolls seem nothing more than inventories of the signs, buildings, and events listed in Meng Yuanlao's *Glorious Dreams of the Eastern Capital*. By the time Meng's book was published in 1187 (the same year *Up to the Capital* was first inscribed) Kaifeng had been in the hands of the Jurchens for more than half a century. Those who fled south following the collapse of the Northern Song in 1127 were comforted by detailed reminiscences of the capital as it used to be, whether written or painted. The Qingming scrolls painted in the south were produced especially for this audience. But Zhang's handscroll has an entirely distinct subject matter and presents a special locale of the capital different from those seen in other Qingming scrolls. Rather than a generic glorious capital, Zhang's painting depicts a port district of Kaifeng, and this must have been an area where elegant people rarely visited.

Indeed, the appearance of an official in a court outfit amidst commoners would have caused a disturbance in the market place. Walking among peddlers, porters, and begging monks, such an official would have disguised himself in plain robes and would have carried a round, fanlike object called a *bianmian* (便面) (fig. 10) to conceal his face.<sup>17</sup> The court musician Liu Ji 劉幾 donned a simple cotton robe whenever he visited Kaifeng's market and red-light districts.<sup>18</sup> It was rare to find high-level officials going incognito in cotton robes in the marketplaces.

A few people in the scroll are shown carrying a *bianmian*, which not only sets them apart from the crowd but also calls attention to them. The vast majority of the people in the scroll are ordinary folk and this is their world; here, officials are outsiders and must cover their faces and identities but not their prestige. We find no such disguised officials depicted in any other versions of the Qingming scroll.

Throughout the painting, the presence of government is minimal. Social order is achieved through the influence of a good ruler — not through policing.

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17. Su Shi (1036–1101) walked around streets of Kaifeng with a *bianmian* on which he had had his portrait painted after he was condemned as one of the criminals of the Yuanyou era. See Zeng Zaozhuang 曾棗莊 et al., eds., *Quan Songwen* 全宋文 (Chengdu: Ba Shu shushe, 1988–), 44:393.

18. Ye Mengde, *Shilin yanyu* 10.147.





Fig. 10. *Bianmian*, a facial concealing devise, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

“When a prince’s personal conduct is correct, his government is effective without the issuing of orders,” wrote Confucius; “If his personal conduct is not correct, he may issue orders, but they will not be followed.”<sup>19</sup> In eleventh century Kaifeng, good rule meant keeping the river open and the grain supplies moving.

### *The Term “Qingming”*

The first colophon to the painting is inscribed “the day after the Qingming 清明,” which has misled many to identify the work as a depiction of the Qingming festival. However, before the Northern Wei (420–589), the term “qingming” was also used to describe an ideal society.<sup>20</sup> Writers of later colophons and

19. Confucius, *Analects*, translated by James Legge, 300.

20. Hong Mai 洪邁, *Rongzhai sui bi, san bi* 容齋隨筆, 三筆 (Changchun: Jilin wenshi Press, 1994), 2.349.



others have thus understood the work to be the commemoration of a peaceful regime. I believe that the word refers to one of the twenty-four solar terms of the Chinese agricultural calendar. Qingming falls on the first day of the fifth term, or around the tenth day of the third lunar month. The term is described in the *Huainan zi* 淮南子, a collection of writings assembled by the King of Huainan 淮南王, Liu An 劉安 (179–122 B.C.E.), for the Han emperor: “[When the Big Dipper] points at Yi, the wind of Qingming arrives,”<sup>21</sup> and “When the Qingming wind arrives, [it’s time to] take out money and silk and visit various lords.”<sup>22</sup> Qingming is a time of sweet, warm winds that blow away the chill of the long winter. Fields were ploughed and seeded and, most importantly, the ice floes in the Yellow River melted.

More than a hundred years after Liu An’s *Huainan zi* was presented to the Han emperor, “qingming” was used as a term of praise. A biography of the historian Ban Gu 班固 (32–92 C.E.) described a period of “pure brightness.”<sup>23</sup> Later, “Qingming shengshi” 清明盛世 (the pure brightness of a prosperous period) was often used to describe an ideal regime. In ancient China these were times of social stability and security and adequate food supplies. Not until the sixth century when the Cold Food (*hanshi* 寒食) festival, which is held primarily to commemorate one’s ancestors, was moved to the day before Qingming did “Qingming” come to refer to a springtime festival. Gradually it came to refer to the final stage of the early spring Cold Food festival.

The Cold Food festival originated in the early fifth century, and celebrates the life of the hermit Jie Zitui 介子推.<sup>24</sup> Jie helped King Wen of the Jin 晉文公 (ca. 636 B.C.E.) to regain the throne, but when his efforts went unrewarded, he retired to the mountains. After the king realized his mistake, he ordered Jie back to court. Jie refused to return. To avoid capture, Jie clung to a tree and perished in a fire set to flush him out. The remorseful King ordered that henceforth no fires should be lit during the month of Jie’s death. When living without fire or hot food for a month in the winter proved too much of a hardship for his subjects, Emperor Wu of the Northern Wei 魏武帝 moved

21. Liu An, *Huainanzi*, 85, 87.

22. Liu An, *Huainanzi*, 85, 95.

23. Fan Ye 范曄 (398–445), “Biography of Ban Gu” 班固, in *Hou Hanshu* 後漢書 [History of the Later Han] (Beijing, 1965), 70.1334.

24. See Chen Yuanjing, *Suishi guangji*, 歲時廣記 (1266) chaps. 15–17. See also Pang Yuan-ying 龐元瑛 (active late eleventh century), *Wenchang zalu* 文昌雜錄 (Shanghai, 1958), 2.18, 3:24.

the date of the Cold Food festival from winter to the beginning of the third month, the day before Qingming.<sup>25</sup> By combining the Cold Food festival and Qingming, Emperor Wu was exhibiting a “pure and bright” thoughtfulness for his people.

By the early Southern Song, the first day of Qingming and the Cold Food festival were one and the same. “The Qingming festival,” writes Meng Yuanlao, “which falls on the hundred and fifth day after the winter solstice (the 22nd solar term), is commonly treated as the day of the major Cold Food festival.”<sup>26</sup> He goes on to describe the three stages (days) of the festival. During the first stage, *chuishu* 炊熟, three days’ worth of food was prepared. Most activities took place the next day, the main day of *hanshi* (the hundred and fifth day after the winter solstice). People celebrated with a visit to the family graves. Qingming was on the third day. And during the Northern Song one had to endure eighteen cold meals, the famous *hanshi shibadun* 寒食十八頓.<sup>27</sup> According to an Eastern Capital folk rhyme, “lazy women cherish the *hanshi* festival.” The most interesting Northern Song account of the festival is by Cai Jing’s 蔡京 second son, Cai Tao 蔡絛, who writes that on the eve of the Qingming festival, all fires—particularly stove fires—were extinguished. In early morning of the fourth day (the third day of the fifth solar term), a cinder would be taken from the palace to rekindle the stoves of a few honored families. After a rekindling ceremony, all stoves were lit.<sup>28</sup> One of the iconic figures of the Song, Su Shi 蘇軾, mentions the rekindling ceremony: “Three times new fires were rekindled on three Qingming Days. Sympathizing with my lingering illness, Mr. Xu of Huangzhou shared his red fire blossom [candle] with me in the early morning. I used it to search for something to cook, but I could find nothing edible.”<sup>29</sup>

Of the scroll’s scenes, those of cooking are among the most prevalent. People are cooking everywhere—on boats, on the streets, in restaurants. The scroll is clearly much more concerned with depictions of eating and drinking than with Qingming festivities. Scholars have speculated that the group of

25. Hong Mai, 2.349.

26. Meng Yuanlao, *Dongjing menghua lu*, in Tao Zongyi, 68: 1.12b–13a.

27. Luo Ye 羅曄, *Zuiweng tanlu* 醉翁談錄, 3.34. See also Zhu Yu 朱彧 (1075–c.a. 1119), *Pingzhou ketan* 萍州可談 (Shanghai, 1989), 2.35.

28. Cai Tao 蔡絛, *Tiewei shan congtan* 鐵圍山叢談, (Wen yuan ge Siku quanshu edition, vol. 1037), 2.21.

29. Su Shi 蘇軾, *Su Dongpo ji* 蘇東坡集 (Shanghai: Commercial Press, 1958), vol. 3, 9.129.



Fig. 11. Sedan-chair returning to the city, a detail from the first part of *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

people shown with a sedan chair at the beginning of the scroll is returning from grave sweeping—an important part of the Cold Food festival.<sup>30</sup> However, upon close examination, we see that the group has in fact returned from a successful hunting trip. One man carries a bow, another a pole with a bird on each end (fig. 11). The weather has turned warm—we see some men are already in their short-sleeve tops and the hunting season has begun (fig. 12). This further establishes that the painting is definitely not a depiction of the Cold Food festival when such activities would have been forbidden.

### *The Canal*

What, then, was the connection between the words “Qingming” and the subject of transportation depicted in the painting?

Maintaining social stability in the capital was crucial, and it depended largely on an ample food supply. History had taught the Song rulers that they risked being overthrown whenever their people’s deprivation and hunger were

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30. See Valerie Hansen, “Mystery.”



Fig. 12. Men with short-sleeve tops, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

beyond tolerance. Throughout the Northern Song, punishments for crimes compelled by hunger were often reduced, and special arrangements were made to support those who were starving.<sup>31</sup> Grain shipments were carefully planned, and the route along the Bian River was deemed the most reliable. In 1065, more than five million *dan* 石 (hectoliters) of grain were shipped into the capital through the Bian River.<sup>32</sup> When the river was closed during the long winter months, the risk of social instability increased as the amount of grain entering the capital dwindled.

Canals were vital for transporting goods. The emperors of the Sui Dynasty (581–618) are commonly credited with the construction of the major canals in China, but *Records of the Grand Historian* describes their much earlier use in connecting China's four major areas: Chu, Wu, Qi and Shu.<sup>33</sup> Kaifeng was chosen as the capital of the Northern Song because of its convenient location on the river. Taizu, the first Song emperor, had planned to relocate his capital from Kaifeng to the famous historical capitals, Luoyang and Chang'an, but he was discouraged by the difficulties of dredging and transporting grain north. "Born in Jiamaying, to the west of the [Tang] capital, Taizu loved the mountains and scenery there and considered relocating the [Song] capital. Li Huaizhong 李懷忠, the Commandant of Fleet-as-Clouds Cavalry, remonstrated, saying, "The capital is located at the center of the universe, surrounded by the Yellow and Bian rivers, by which grain reserves can be

31. In the *Song shi* it is said that the policy of reducing punishment for starvation-related crimes came from *Zhou Li* [Institutions of Zhou] (ca. 1042–771 B.C.E.); see *Song shi* 200.4988.

32. *Song shi* 175.4253.

33. Sima Qian 司馬遷, "Book of Rivers and Canals," in *Shiji* [Records of the Grand Historian 史記] (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1959), 29.1407.

supplied to tens of thousands of people without hauling about caravans. It should never be relocated unadvisedly.”<sup>34</sup> Throughout the Northern Song, relocating the capital was discussed many times but always discouraged.

From the time of Taizu's reign to the end of the Northern Song—a period of one hundred sixty-seven years—a constant battle was waged against the flooding and silting up of the waterways surrounding the capital. “In the last two thousand years, rivers have been China's perils,” remonstrated a Ren Boyu 任伯雨, Left Exhorter of the Huizong court; “Throughout the last two thousand years, no other dynasty has exhausted more of its resources to regulate the rivers than our own.”<sup>35</sup> Rivers and canals not only provided convenient and efficient trade and supply routes, but also powered waterwheels to process grain and other machines. The benefits (and difficulties) of keeping roads and waterways clear and in good repair are depicted in many texts and paintings of the period.

In particular, the Northern Song government spent much time and effort managing and improving the Bian River system. One difficult problem was removing silt from the canal bed perennially or the river would overflow. More serious, however, were the numerous ice floes (*lingpai* 凌牌) that covered the Yellow River as it began to thaw. Carried along by the swift current, they posed a serious danger to boats, bridges, and other property.<sup>36</sup> Occasionally dikes were damaged and even lives lost.<sup>37</sup> To protect the canal and cities around it, a winter dike was built where the Bian and the Yellow rivers met. Water could no longer enter the Bian, and river traffic ceased until the dike was removed after the early spring of the third lunar month, or early April.

### *Up to the Capital at Qingming*

The scenes in *Up to the Capital* could have occurred on any day after the first day of the Qingming term, when the mouth of the Bian River was opened to

34. Wen Ying 文瑩 (active late eleventh century), *Yuhu qinghua* 玉壺清話 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1984), 7.65.

35. *Song shi* 93.2310.

36. *World Journal* (25 March, 2001, A6), reported ice floes more than six kilometers in length rushing down the Yellow River and threatening its lower reaches. Every year, when most of the ice has melted, the Yellow River is an untamable torrent of rushing water and ice. In a report dated three days earlier (March 22, 2001) *World Journal* states that the ice should melt in ten to fourteen days, or around April 4<sup>th</sup> or 5<sup>th</sup>—the start of *Qingming*.

37. Zhang Dun 章惇. “Qing Bian ji” 清汴記 in *Quan Songwen* 1797.418.



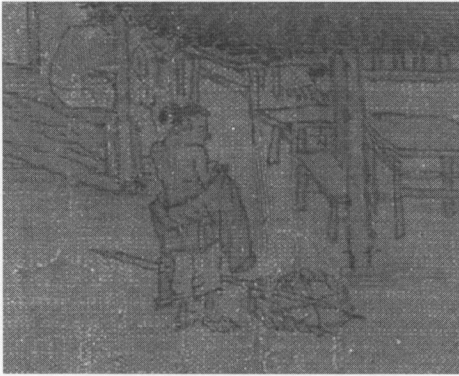


Fig. 13. Louse-picking, a detail from *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

its feeder, the Yellow River, and boats could travel to the capital. Specifically, it could be “the day after [the first day of] Qingming,” as inscribed in the first colophon. The scroll specifies the warm weather of this time of year by presenting a poor peasant taking off his cotton-coated jacket and removing lice (fig. 13). Once the mouth of the Bian was opened, the Yellow River’s current rushed down to fill the canal for abundant river traffic. According to the eleventh century official Zhang Dun 章惇: “On the first day of Qingming 清明日至, water from the Yellow River was again drawn into the Bian, and there was not a single day when the Bian was not filled with numerous, heavily laden vessels arriving side by side.”<sup>38</sup>

The government normally invested an enormous amount of money and manpower to build the winter dike before the Yellow River froze and to dredge the silted Bian the following spring.<sup>39</sup> Although the dike was necessary to protect the canal and the surrounding area, it limited use of the canal to little more than two hundred days each year. When it was suggested that the river be kept open all year round, the famous official Feng Jing 馮京 stated: “I always feel that it would not be safe to do so [during winter], although this would allow us to ship one or two million more [dan 石] of grain to the capital. From the river mouth to Sizhou 泗州, many soldiers and laborers have already been employed [to work on the canal]. If the temperature should drop drastically overnight, ice floes would rush down in great quantity: what would we do then?” Another official asked: “Would it be more convenient if we close the river later and open it earlier [in the year]?” Shenzong Emperor deemed the

38. Zhang Dun, “Qing Bian ji.”

39. Zhang Dun, “Qing Bian ji.”

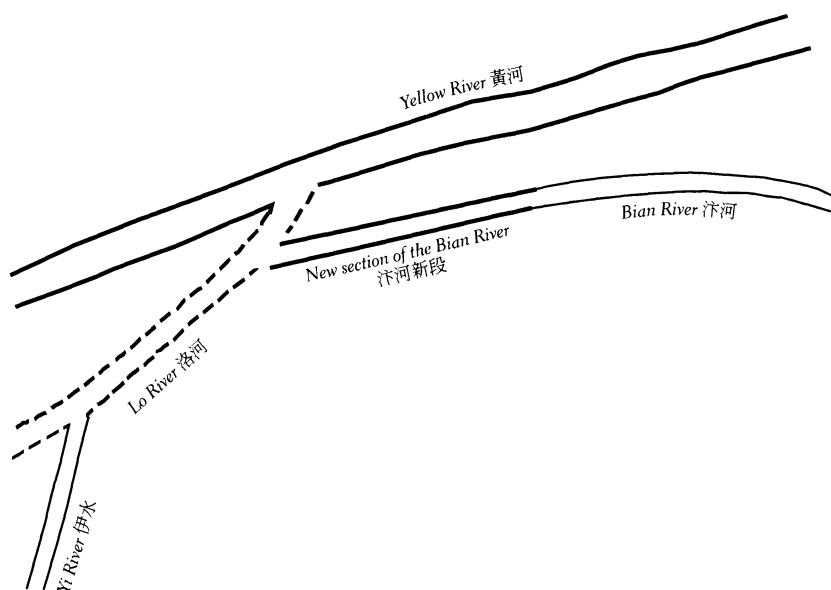


Fig. 14. Map of the rerouted canal.

matter “worthy of investigation. If possible, the project of purifying the Bian would benefit ten thousand generations.”<sup>40</sup>

By the mid-tenth century, large quantities of sediment had accumulated in the Bian, raising the waterbed nearly four yards above ground level.<sup>41</sup> Flooding became a serious threat. This danger, combined with the urgent need for river transportation year round, called for drastic renovation of the canal. A revolutionary solution was proposed in the late 1070s: reroute the Bian’s source from the Yellow to the Luo river. The perfect opportunity arose about this time as the Yellow River began shifting its course farther north, exposing a large area of reclaimed land between the Guanwu Mountains and the Luo River (fig. 14). A topographical report predicted that the rerouting would be successful: “The Directorate of Waterways (*dushi jiancheng* 都水監丞) Fan Ziyuan 范子淵 reported: ‘By order of [the emperor], the topographical survey was completed. In the region ten miles from Heyin 河陰 to the Luo River, the west side of the terrain is higher than the east; conditions are perfect for

40. Li Tao 李濤, *Xu zizhi tongjian changbian* 續資治通鑑長編 (hereafter *Changbian*) (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1986), 252.6175–6176.

41. Shi Nianhai 史念海, *Zhongguo de yunhe* 中國的運河 [Canals of China] (Xi’an: Shaanxi renmin chubanshe, 1988), 228.

rerouting the water source. I suggest more officials of waterways be sent to conduct another survey.”<sup>42</sup> In 1079, after the project inauguration ceremony, a second canal was built that drew water from the Luo River.<sup>43</sup> This brought an end to the annual ritual of removing the winter dike on the first day of Qingming. The river reopening ceremony, which had not been elaborate to begin with, gradually faded from memory. The rerouted water was much cleaner, providing water for drinking and other uses.<sup>44</sup> The capital was no longer threatened with floods.

“In the summer of the third year of the Yuanfeng [1080] Era,”<sup>45</sup> wrote Zhang Dun, in his “Record of the Purification of the Bian,” “the Son of Heaven ordered the construction of a new canal between the Bian River and the Luo River to avoid using water from the Yellow River. The new canal was chiseled out along the base of the Guangwu Mountains to channel the water from the Luo to the Bian, which uses water from all directions. The canal now flowed slowly to the southeast with a deep, clear, smooth current—one not at all ferocious or forceful; it did not dry out, either in winter or spring. After this [accomplishment], the potency of the landscape and the beauty and wealth of the capital reached its perfection.”<sup>46</sup>

Pleased with the success of the new canal, Shenzong ordered a temple to be built at the intersection of the Bian and Luo rivers, and a stele engraved with Zhang’s “Record of Purifying the Bian” was erected. Rerouting the Bian was not only a technological achievement, it also demonstrated good governance by the emperor. “The spring after the completion of the project was a very dry one, and the old route of the Bian River was dried out and the canal bed exposed,” lamented Zhang. “Thanks to the Son of Heaven, who is indeed holy, wise, and far-seeing, who transcends material limits and rigid conventions, who penetrates layers of obstacles with bright light and activates heavenly energy without end. . . . More than the building of a canal has been achieved.”<sup>47</sup> The emperor had brought his people into harmony.

Many government policies were modified after the rerouting. The State

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42. Li Tao, *Changbian*, 295.7182.

43. Li Tao, *Changbian*, 298.7257.

44. *Song shi*, 94.2328.

45. Zhang Dun, “Qing Bian ji.” According to this passage, the new canal was begun in 1080. Later, however, Zhang Dun states that construction started with the topographical survey at the end of 1078. Six months later, in 1079, the canal was completed.

46. Zhang Dun, “Qing Bian ji.”

47. Zhang Dun, “Qing Bian ji.”

Finance Commission (三司) suggested: "Previously, the Supply Commission (發運司) scheduled the first shipment of grain to fall on the first day of Qingming. After the water from the Luo River was channeled into the Bian, the date was changed to the first day of the second month. As of winter, when the Bian River was left running [i.e., when no winter dike was built], it is no longer necessary to continue using the second month [to inaugurate the annual grain shipments]."<sup>48</sup> The slow current and clear water made traveling on the river easier and safer: "When the water from the Yellow River was drawn into the Bian, the flow of the current was so swift that the number of damaged boats and lives lost was very high. But now, the current in the Bian River is clear and much slower."<sup>49</sup>

In short, for a hundred and twenty years during the first part of the Northern Song, the first day of Qingming had coincided with the opening of the Bian River. After the rerouting of 1079, when the river remained open all year round, Qingming took on a different meaning. Within forty years after the reign of Shenzong, the economic and political implications of Qingming had been forgotten, and the season came to be viewed simply as a time of festivities and celebration. It is not surprising that Meng Yuanlao and others of his time saw *Up to the Capital* simply as a work commemorating a wise ruler or depicting a festival without associating it with the changing route of the canal.<sup>50</sup>

Now, let us revisit the scroll *Up to the Capital*, a work that has a general mood of jubilation without any indications of a specific festival. It seems that the purpose of the scroll was to show the successful shipping of much-needed grain to the capital following the opening of the Bian at Qingming, in the period before the change of the feeder of the canal. Before 1079 the Bian River was connected with the Yellow River and on this day the mouth of the Bian was opened; but after this time, the Bian River was channeled to the Luo River and the opening and closing of the river mouth was no longer necessary. This painting depicts exactly the celebratory time when the river mouth was opened on the first day of Qingming. Vessels of all shapes and sizes

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48. Li Tao, *Changbian* 302.7351.

49. Li Tao, *Changbian* 304.7409.

50. Nowhere does Meng mention the opening of the canal on Qingming, because the change of the route of the canal took place at least forty years before his time and the event had faded from public memory. As we have seen, by his time, Qingming meant no more than a stage in the process of the Cold Food festival.

laden with passengers, sacks of grain, and other goods, are shown going up the river that traveled through Kaifeng (fig. 3) passing villages and busy shops and restaurants. The painting is above all about efficient and sufficient access to the Bian River during Qingming when the mouth of the Bian was reopened. The general celebratory mood portrayed in the work takes on a very specific referent once we learn of the opening of the canal mouth on the first day of Qingming. No other paintings of this subject and title after this date make a connection between sailing up the Bian and Qingming; instead they make every effort to add festival or celebratory specificities.

### Conclusion

*Up to the Capital* is a visual record of a day in early spring along the Bian River. Boats heavily laden with grain and other goods fill the canal, which has only just opened to river traffic after a long winter. People are enjoying themselves with food and drink in boats, in the street, and along the riverbanks. After the rerouting of the Bian in 1079, the people of Kaifeng no longer had to wait until Qingming for the winter dike to be removed and shipping to resume. Thus, this painting that depicts the celebratory mood of that occasion must have been created before 1079. Within a few decades, the connection between Qingming and the canal opening was forgotten, and the original intent of the painting was lost. The collective memory failed to register the connection of the canal and the first day of Qingming, and that failure eventually led to a misinterpretation of this work, and ultimately to the creation of more than forty other versions of *Qingming Shanghe tu*.

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